

A good administrator?

Many modern historians have criticised Alexander's efforts to administer his empire. A number of satraps had to be replaced when Alexander returned from India in 324BC.

Modern historians say that the number of satraps and government officials that Alexander had to replace in 324BC indicates poor judgment on his part when choosing governors and officials in the first place.

Reliable officials

For provincial management Alexander originally used Persians as civil administrators as they had the best local knowledge but kept the military in the hands of Macedonians. This practice gave the conquered nobles the idea that they were part of the new government, which should have decreased the chances of conspiracy and rebellion.

The use of Persians as satraps did not work well in most instances. The eastern satraps proved rebellious and incompetent. In 330BC Satibarzanes revolted in Artacoana (Arrian 3.25). In 329BC Arsaces, the satrap of Aria, was replaced by Stasanor, a Greek. Proexes, satrap of Parapamisadae in north western India, was dismissed for incompetence (Arrian 4.22).

Persians of the calibre of Mazaeus, the satrap of Babylon, and Artabazus, the satrap of Bactria, were hard to find. AB Bosworth suggests that the satraps that were replaced in 325–324BC were all troublemakers who had shown signs of plotting against Alexander rather than incompetent officials. By 324BC key eastern satrapies such as Bactria, Sogdiana, Aria and Arachosia were all in the hands of Macedonians or Greeks.

Insubordination vs. incompetence

The problem was not strictly a Persian one. High-ranking Macedonians like Cleander and Sitalces were also tried and executed on charges of misgovernment and plunder (Arrian 6.27).

Harpalus, the empire's treasurer and a long-time companion of Alexander, was even found guilty of stealing funds from the royal treasury at Babylon.

Whatever your opinion as to whether Alexander was a good administrator or not, three things must be kept in mind:

- he planned the administrative organisation of the empire while on campaign, varying his system depending on the area, its people and his needs
- his campaigning in the east and northern India kept him out of effective communication with the western section of his empire for long periods of time after 329BC
- he died young and had little real time, free from campaigning, to change the administration of the empire, if in fact he ever intended to.

Did power go to his head?

Trouble in the camp

Incidents like Philotas' and Parmenio's executions (330BC), the murder of Cleitus, the Conspiracy of the Pages and the execution of Callisthenes the official court historian (327BC) were indications of unhappiness amongst the Macedonian nobles and Greeks. Various incidents had affected Alexander's relationship with these two groups. He had, after 330BC, started to adopt Persian dress and customs (Plutarch, *Life of Alexander*, 45) in an attempt to make the Persians happy. He saw value in being accepted as the Great King rather than as a Macedonian conqueror. This move was seen by some of the Macedonians and Greeks as a sign of

Was he great?

Any attempt to assess the strengths and weaknesses of an historical personality is subjective. Perhaps the best assessment of Alexander's right to claim the title 'the Great' was undertaken by Arrian at the end of his work.

He had great personal beauty, invincible power of endurance, and a keen intellect; he was brave and adventurous, strict in the observance of his religious duties, and hungry for fame.

Doubtless, in the passion of the moment Alexander sometimes made mistakes; it is true he took some steps towards the pomp and arrogance of the Asiatic kings: but I, at least, cannot feel that such errors were very wrong, if the circumstances are taken fairly into consideration. For, after all, he was young; the chain of his successes was unbroken, and, like all kings, past, present, and to come, he was surrounded by courtiers who spoke to please, regardless of what evil their words might do. On the other hand, I do indeed know that Alexander, of all the monarchs of old, was the only one who had the nobility of heart to be sorry for his mistakes.

Surely, too, his adoption of Persian dress was, like his claim to divine birth, a matter of policy: by it he hoped to bring the Eastern nations to feel that they had a king who was not wholly a foreigner, and to indicate to his own countrymen his desire to move away from the harsh traditional arrogance of Macedonia. That was also, no doubt, the reason why he included a proportion of Persian troops (the so-called 'Golden Apples', for instance) in Macedonian units, and made Persian noblemen officers in his crack native regiments.

It is my belief that there was in those days no nation, no city, no single individual beyond the reach of Alexander's name; never in all the world was there another like him ...

THE CAMPAIGNS OF ALEXANDER, 7.28–30